the Gangsters Act is up before the courts on April 29.

There are also uncomfortable silences in the narrative. While Yogi has come down equally hard on Hindu mafiosi, local nuance often ascribes to it a caste angle. The July 2020 encounter of Kanpur gangster Vikas Dubey—one of the bloodiest, costing the lives of eight policemen—exemplifies both aspects. He was one in UP's long line of Brahmin gangsters, running from Hari Shankar Tiwari and Amar Mani Tripathi in the 1980s-90s, and his violent end once again invited the counter-suggestion that the Yogi administration pulls its punches when it involves big Thakur dons. This resonates the most when it comes to the badlands of eastern Uttar Pradesh, a grungy locale that has gained enough infamy to make it to blood-splattered OTT hits like *Mirzapur* and *Rangbaaz*.

Yogi's critics cite Brijesh Singh, the dreaded don of Poorvanchal, as Exhibit A—though the fact that he figures in the list of 66 bolsters the official denial of any leniency. The one-time sharp-shooter for Dawood Ibrahim with a MCOCA case against him is an arch-foe of Mukhtar. The 2001 Usri Chatti shootout for which the latter is now in the dock was ironically a sensational attack on Mukhtar's cavalcade by Brijesh's gang—and the slain man whose father has filed a murder case now was one of his shooters. An MLC seat in Varanasi has been Brijesh's family monopoly for 25 years—his wife won that seat last year against the BJP, in the heart of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Lok Sabha constituency, in Yogi's UP. And his nephew is a BJP MLA.

Nor is he the only one, say the chief minister's critics. There is ex-MP and mafioso Dhananjay Singh, who counts Jaunpur as his turf but has blithely eluded justice after a grisly 2021 murder (and is not on the list). Or the sharp-suited Badan Singh Baddo out west in Meerut, who merrily mocked a former top cop on Instagram while at large even as his illegal factory was razed by Yogi's bulldozers. There are others too: Kuldeep Singh Sengar of Unnao rape infamy who got a noticeably long rope, good old Raghuraj Pratap Singh alias 'Raja Bhaiyya' who's a law unto himself in Kunda...in fact, a whole menagerie of Singhs. The exception who had the Gangsters Act coming down on him, along with property seizures running into Rs 2.5 crore, was Dhruv (or 'Kuntu') Singh of Azamgarh. Officials brush aside the criticism, saying the chief minister goes after all dons with equal measure of force. Yogi himself has in the past dismissed allegations that he has a soft corner for those belonging to the Thakur community, including in promotions, as patently false.

THE POLITICIAN-CRIMINAL NEXUS

Atiq exemplified the ideology-free nature of the mafia and its interface with politics, but was not the first one to do so. Uttar Pradesh moved out of its old days of dacoity and into modern organised crime as it started receiving development funds in the 1980s, setting off sanguinary battles for tenders and contracts, with some good old *rangdaari*, or extortion, spread on for jam. The new hustlers who specialised in this gradually moved up the value chain to other resource-rich zones before, eventually, making the inevitable 'forward integration' into politics. No party was driven snow here. Hari Shankar Tiwari, the first of the dons of Poorvanchal, spread his love from the Congress to the BJP to the SP and the BSP, holding a state cabinet post under Kalyan Singh, Mulayam Singh Yadav, Rajnath Singh and Mayawati. As for Atiq, it's the SP that is most associated with him and, for many, he typifies the 'lawless' days of Mulayam against which the rest of the landscape is compared, usually favourably.

A closer look, however, reveals intriguing layers. Atiq was twice with the undivided Apna Dal, the last time even serving as its president—the present chief of its main legatee party, Anupriya Patel, is a Union minister. When he joined forces with her father Sonelal Patel to field candidates around Allahabad, he would splinter the Muslim vote and tack a percentage of it on to Patel's Kurmi base, naturally to the advantage of the SP's rivals, the BJP included. And the readmission of controversial figures like Atiq was one of the flashpoints in the famous family feud between Mulayam and son Akhilesh. Atiq had deep contacts in the BJP too—a long list of luminaries that may embarrass the party if it ever comes out.

SEVEN WEEKS ON THE RUN, WITH A Rs 5 LAKH BOUNTY ON HIS HEAD, ENDED IN A HAIL OF BULLETS IN THE JHANSI 'ENCOUNTER' FOR ATIQ'S SON ASAD



ANI